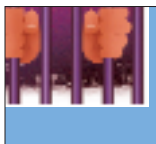


Blame Game Gone Bad!

A picture portraying Shivaji in a poor light was posted on Orkut, and a hue and cry ensued. Police got the offending IP from Google. Airtel, the ISP, obliged them with a name. A Bangalore-based techie was jailed, then 50 days later, released without charges. Talk about bad name resolution...



Tenuous Link

Bangladesh was offline for most of the day November 13: the sabotage stopped all Internet use. There was a nationwide investigation. What baffles us is that reports say "Cables were cut." *Cables* were cut and a country goes offline? We're as lost as you are—don't ask us for an explanation.



newsbytes



Security Watch

Windows URI Handling Vulnerability

The Problem

Mid-November, Microsoft issued a software update to fix a security vulnerability in Windows versions including XP SP2. Criminal groups have been targeting that vulnerability to break into machines and steal data.

The patch fixes a critical flaw found in Windows XP and Windows Server 2003 systems that also have Internet Explorer 7 installed. The vulnerability is not present in Windows Vista.

As some background, for more than a month prior to that, cyber-criminals have been sending out spam messages containing malicious links or Adobe PDF documents that try to install spyware when the user clicks the links or opens the files respectively.

According to Microsoft, "a remote code execution vulnerability exists in the way that the Windows shell handles specially crafted URIs that are passed to it. If the Windows shell did not sufficiently validate these URIs, an attacker could exploit this vulnerability and execute arbitrary code."

The Solution

The vulnerability is quite critical, and if you haven't heard of anything like "the URI vulnerability" or "the PDF vulnerability," visit www.microsoft.com/technet/security/Bulletin/MS07-061.msp (http://tinyurl.com/2dbxdu) ASAP and patch your system. The page has all you need to know.

LOTS IN A NAME?

The Web: Even More Global

Mid-November, the Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN) announced plans to "fast-track" the development of country-coded top level domains (ccTLDs).

Some background: you've noticed that all domain names use only 37 characters—the letters A to Z, the numerals 0 to 9, and the dash. All these are "Latin" characters—so it imposes a restriction on the people of countries where these aren't used. For example, as you know, you can't have (and type out) a domain name in Hindi.

This means several things—inconvenience for those not familiar with the Latin alphabet, a sense of alienation for them (because of having to type in something they never would), and the incongruence of naming a domain in one language and typing it out in another.

So back in March of this year, ICANN launched a campaign to provide internationalised ccTLDs, with the co-operation of the Country Code Names Supporting Organisation (ccNSO).

Already, many countries whose languages use non-Latin characters had been demanding the ability to use Internationalised Domain Names (IDNs). Those in support of IDNs saw that development as an important step towards

keeping the Internet a non-fragmented, global entity.

We learn that it's not as straightforward as it might seem: ICANN had, in October of 2006, commissioned a laboratory test of the new kinds of domain names. International characters would have to be encoded, and ICANN intended to find whether the use of the encoded characters would "have any impact on the operations of the root name servers providing delegations, or the iterative mode resolvers."

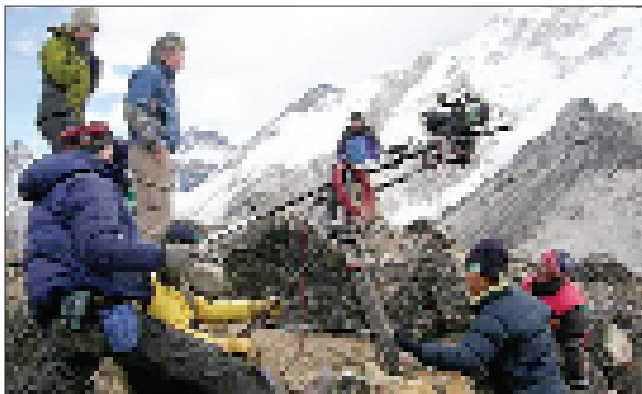
Then, in March, the results were announced: the tests had been

Japanese—which you'll have to copy and paste—that you'll imagine what it's been like all these years for those not familiar with "our" alphabet!

CONNECTED WELL AND TRULY

Tech On The Hill

Mount Everest is now (un)wired. November 14, a Chinese mobile phone provider tested—successfully—a transmission station on the world's



successful. "No impact at all could be detected," wrote tester Lars-Johan Liman. "All involved systems behaved exactly as expected."

And now, in this "fast-track" bid, the next step "is to develop the policies that will see the creation of new top-level domains in characters from the languages of the world."

It's only after you see a domain name in, say,

tallest mountain. The intention is to enable calls by casual climbers—there seem to be many such now—as well as those performing in the 2008 Olympic torch relay. The relay will carry the Olympic torch to the top; the site of the station is at 6,500 metres. This station—as well as two others—would provide service along the entire climb.

At first, it sounds sensational—"Mount Everest is connected."—this is the tallest mountain we're talking about. The underlying thought is that if we can do this—yes, the project was very difficult indeed—then we can connect pretty much anywhere.

And then, on second thought, it begins to sound quite ordinary: there really isn't a conceptual big deal about putting a tower someplace on a mountain, is there?

But then again, this is a landmark in connectivity. It's not too far off, the day when you'll be able to call anybody from anywhere—and this bit of news just reminds us of that.

THE DEVIL AND THE DEEP SEA

Online's Unhealthy—Again

Kids are getting fat and lazy, at least in countries where there's a lot of money—for example, the UK. There are too many reasons to mention, but not least amongst these is the Internet and the value it holds for young people.

The UK Children's Minister, Beverly Hughes, recently blamed MySpace and co. for their part in the sad phenomenon of kids not being outdoors enough. A recent report by a think-tank called Demos details how "the benefits of a good public realm for children and young people are part of the benefits it gives the rest of society," going on to talk about the lack of formal playgrounds and such, and how traffic keeps children off public space.

The report says, "In one national study, 45 per cent of 500 children interviewed said they were not allowed to play with water, 36 per

Post The Move

This was one traumatic month—we shifted office all the way from one place along what was called the Bombay-Pune highway to another place on the Bombay-Pune highway. Adding to the trauma somewhat is the fact that our old security guards are no longer with us; we're feeling a little insecure.

So well, what's the impact been? Looking at some who have been here a while, let's see who's happy and why. **Raabo:** Because this place is less distant from civilisation. You see, Robert and a million others define "actual Bombay" as "civilisation," and all the rest of the metropolitan area as "the villages." **Nimish:** He lives in an even more highly-civilised place, so he's pleased, too. **Deepak the Ed:** Because the new office is smaller, his oath-laden speech is easily audible to all without his having to

digit DIARY

repeat. As an added bonus, other departments can hear him, too, and better understand his gentle nature.

Now who's unhappy, disgruntled, and in a vague mood of protest?

Ram: The obvious first in this category. He needs to travel by train for the first time in his life, his coffee is served in smaller cups, and if those horrible things weren't enough, the lift isn't operational yet—so he must actually climb up *three flights of stairs* a day!

Vijay: No place by a window for a thoughtful, almost-meditative smoke. (We're reporting this, but Vijay's sincere appeal to all of you is to never smoke.) **Sanket:** That Test Centre was his Own. This one isn't. Yet.

Anyway, we're still a small, happy family, 'cause the line is thinly drawn 'tween joy and sorrow, as the song goes.

WIRE POWER

Tech In The Real/Real World

Mid-November, during the crackdown on dissent by Pakistani President Pervez Musharraf, young Pakistanis were using blogs and social networking sites to do what they could to voice and demonstrate dissent. For example, plans for "flash" protests in large cities were posted at the last minute. This was after the government shut down the country's two largest private television news channels.

Cell phone messaging was being used as well to co-ordinate dissent efforts. As representative of what was going on, one student said, "We let students know through Facebook groups and blogs when the protests are taking place. We are having flash protests for five or ten minutes so we do not get caught."

The most popular Facebook protest group was *We Oppose Emergency in Pakistan*, which had more than 11,000 members mid-November.

It's not a one-off incident, and neither is it restricted to protests: "Blogs and Facebook are starting to change the way young Pakistanis think because people who aren't usually interested in politics are being exposed to it," said Hamza Sadiq Khan, creator of Facebook group "Go Musharraf Go!!!"

If you remember, communication via blogs and cell phones played an important role—in India and in other countries—in the rescue efforts after the tsunamis of 2005.

These, given the very low Internet penetration in countries like India and Pakistan. One need only think of the countries being fully-connected to imagine just to what extent the Internet can empower.

How is the Internet perceived by officials in authoritarian states? China naturally comes to mind, with its Net censorship and other measures and policies.

As Internet penetration increases in developing countries, it'll be interesting to watch two things: first, whether access will bridge divides or actually increase them; second, whether regimes that want to do so can effectively police access. ■